Vayigash 5785

After the dramatic meeting between יוסף and his brothers, when יוסף finally reveals himself, he gives specific instructions regarding how to bring יעקב down to מצרים. The very last words יוסף tells them are in the פסוק (45:24): וַיְשַׁלַּח אֶת אֶחָיו וַיֵּלֵכוּ וַיֹּאמֶר אֲלֵהֶם אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ. The מפרשים discuss the meaning of the unique phrase אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ. רש"י provides two פשטים, the first פשט is: אַל תִּתְעַסְּקוּ בְּדָבָר הֲלָכָה שֶׁלֹּא תִרְגְּזוּ עֲלֵיכֶם הַדֶּרֶךְ. Simply put, יוסף tells them, "Don't engage in an intense halachic discussion on your way back to ארץ ישראל because you might lose focus and get lost on the road."

There are two parallel, beautiful דברי תורה, one from the אַפְרִיוֹן (which is from רב שלמה גאנצפריד, the famous author of the קיצור שולחן ערוך) and one from the Brisker Rav, which complement each other. The אַפְרִיוֹן raises a question: If יוסף warns his brothers not to engage in הלכה during their travels, why didn't יעקב give them the same warning earlier? He answers by pointing out a deeper layer of this story.

The בני יעקב had realized that their father's 22-year absence in חרן without fulfilling the מצוה of כיבוד אב was connected to יעקב's suffering of losing יוסף for 22 years. (While יעקב had left home under his parents' directive, the דין was still מדוקדק for צדיקים, measuring them כחוט השערה.) Although the עונש was decreed משמים, the brothers understood that they were the גורמים of יעקב's pain and bore responsibility for his suffering. Therefore, they themselves will have to give a דין on it, as is brought down clearly in פרקי אבות (2:6): עַל דַּאֲטֵפְתָּ, אַטְפוּךְ. וְסוֹף מְטַיְפַיִךְ יְטוּפוּן, the famous saying of הלל, when he saw a skull in the water. "You were killed because you were a killer, and those who killed you, will meet the same fate." The אַפְרִיוֹן cites a גאון (possibly the מהרי"ץ חיות) who explains that the brothers, as the גורמים of יעקב's pain, would need to undergo מידה כנגד מידה despite being שליחים of Hashem, because we say מגלגלין חוב על ידי חייב.

However, the brothers noted a critical distinction between יוסף's 22 years and יעקב's 22 years: יעקב's 14 years spent learning תורה were not included in the דין, teaching them that תלמוד תורה is greater than כיבוד אב. This realization inspired the brothers to seek כפרה for their role in יעקב's suffering by intensifying their תורה learning, even while on the road. However, יוסף, a maven on the brothers' enormous capacity to scale the heights of torah scholarship, cautioned them with the words אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ, advising them that the dangers of the road outweighed the benefits of their heightened learning.

The Brisker Rav complements the above. He brings רש"י from מסכת תענית דף י ע"ב, which says: אַל תִּתְעַסְּקוּ בְּדָבָר הֲלָכָה, שֶׁמָּא תְּרַגְּזוּ עֲלֵיכֶם הַדֶּרֶךְ - that the road should not be a danger to you, that you should not get lost. The גמרא continues: אָמַר רַבִּי אִלְעַאי בַּר בָּרְכְיָה: שְׁנֵי תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים שֶׁמְּהַלְּכִים בַּדֶּרֶךְ וְאֵין בֵּינֵיהֶן דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה רְאוּיִין לִישָׂרֵף - If two תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים are walking and don't learn תורה, they have to be destroyed. This directly contradicts what יוסף was telling them?

The Brisker Rav resolves the apparent contradiction: יוסף's warning specifically addressed לימוד בעיון, an intense and absorbing level of learning. While regular תורה study is essential even during travel, engaging in בעיון could cause them to lose focus and endanger themselves.

The Brisker Rav brings an additional vort, important to transmit to you as well: When יוסף revealed himself earlier in the פרשה, he says (45:3) אֲנִי יוֹסֵף הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי. The פסוק continues: וְלֹא יָכְלוּ אֶחָיו לַעֲנוֹת אֹתוֹ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו. The מדרש תנחומא (5:11) says פָּרְחָה נִשְׁמָתָן - that the brothers were so overwhelmed that they actually died, and Hashem performed תחיית המתים.

Now, this אֲנִי יוֹסֵף was astounding to them. They were coming to מצרים on the small chance they might possibly find יוסף in this tremendously vast country. And if, in fact, they do find him, which was unlikely, he would be an עבד עבדים in some who-knows-where. Now they see he is the מושל of מצרים, and not only that, he is the one who has been giving them all of this וכוחַ from the moment that they got there; it never entered their minds that this is יוסף. This was so astonishing, so overwhelming, so incredible, that נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו.

https://youtu.be/yXGVSlLR210

Then the Brisker Rav says his interesting insight: let's say this happened to us? If we had such an astounding revelation which knocks out all of our preconceived notions in one shot, it would take us a while to assimilate that, it would take us a while to get that under our belts. However, who are we talking about? We're talking about שבטים. As soon as they came to, they said, "We've got to sit down and learn better". They didn't sit and wonder about this amazing turn of events, contemplating on it for hours or days or weeks. "We've got to sit down and learn, and we've got to learn hard, because that's our תפקיד right now. We've got to sit and learn תורה with even greater diligence, in order that we should be able to be מכפר on our עבירות." Therefore, יוסף had to tell them אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ - "Yes, you can do that, but don't do it on the road, because that would be dangerous and not in your best interests."

This profound insight holds an important lesson. When we face difficulties or challenges, our response should be what Hashem wants from us - engaging in תורה and מצוות with renewed dedication. By doing so, we take the opportunity to create a זכות for ourselves, our families, and all of כלל ישראל.